holding the puppy in my arms. He paused in front of the garage and anchored his gaze on a light-blue vintage car.

'What is the matter, Papaji?' I asked, breaking the silence.

'You see that car?' he said excitedly, and I nodded. 'It's a 1951 Studebaker Champion! One of my favourites.'

Confusion puckered my brows. 'So?' I asked.

'So,' he smiled at me and looked back at the car, 'I want to buy it.'

'But it's an old car!' I exclaimed.

'It's a bullet-nose vintage beauty, Gunju,' he said. 'Do you know it's a limited-edition car with a spinner-grille? There's a difference between "old" and "vintage".' He then walked up to the mechanic inside the garage and asked him if the car was for sale. I stood there, wondering if he actually meant to buy it. The mechanic told him the car belonged to His Highness, the Maharaja of Gwalior, Madhavrao Scindia. He came back to me and said, 'Let's go.'

'Yes, let's go, who wants to buy an old car anyway?' I said. I thought he had given up.

He kick-started the scooter and said, 'We're going to meet the maharaja.'

His Highness lived in the Jai Vilas Palace in Gwalior—the residence of the descendants of the Maratha Scindia dynasty, part of which had been converted into a museum in 1964. When we got on the road leading to the front gate of the palace, a huge white building came into view. The road was lined with beautifully trimmed trees and hedges. There were other tourists going in the same direction, probably to see the museum. As we got closer, I could see the beautiful European architecture of the stunning three-storey grand edifice. There was a round marble fountain in front of the main gate. Papaji parked his scooter in the visitors' parking spot, and we walked towards the main gate. Upon enquiring from the guards, Papaji learnt that the maharaja was available at his residence, but nobody was allowed inside the premises. Papaji insisted on meeting him, saying the maharaja wouldn't deny him permission once he learnt that an army officer had come with a special request. Papaji was hell-bent on meeting him and I could see there was no way he was going to back off. The guards could see it too, so they